

THE WORLD IS ENDING

AND WE MUST PREPARE

A short-story-novelette combo I wrote circa May 2024 (and potentially before/beyond that) about ignorance and whatever else. Absolutely useless, but full of silliness and references to my prev. works :)

Fire

The great fire came on the twenty-third of March. There were no survivors to speak of; that was, none to recount their experiences and daring rescues, which ruined morale for miles around. What good was there in a natural disaster with no silver lining?

Much too late, residents realised the fire's true severity. Not only did it kill spirits, but it resisted all conventional methods of extinguishment; see thoughts, goodwill, and prayers. Great biblical columns licked over fields and valleys, and crossed hills quite simply as if to laugh, "Catch me if you can", hissing in the face of complacency. Acres seared in the heat of their insult.

As the rising sun roped in that day, she brought with her red-hot retribution— rolling hills of smoke— suffocating, I-told-you-so ash that dusted rooftops like snow, dry on tongue-tips and burnt eyes. With each flicker and spark, a new devilish face would creep from its door of flame, contorted every which way, sacrilegious char and blasphemous prayer as pressure-cooker whistles. Bursting its way through windows. Melting glass. The people, if they did not scream, conceded and knelt. And the star sat by, soon to burn up herself.

Nobody moved. Nobody *wanted* to move until the very last moment, once the conflagration had devoured their family and they stood, nursing singed fingers, amidst rubble and ash. At which point they usually began to cry. Salt smothers flames, but it is known that no amount of tears will put out a fire.

Temperatures began rising around the first of March. Town hall scheduled a meeting to discuss whether climate change existed, or whether the thirty-degree upticks could be ascribed to something tangible like Sylvia Milne's basement rituals. Sylvia Milne denied any involvement, and instead brought up nearby instances of similar issues. The next county over

had a warm February. The county two counties over had a warm February. The country three counties over also had a warm February, and so on. And they'd all experienced some modicum of conscious combustion.

What happened to their folk, then? Did they survive? Did their planting seasons shift? Were firefighters smart enough to save them? Council members asked.

Milne simply encouraged town hall representatives to watch the television. Best prepare for something catching aflame here too, she said, since God knows what kids and dogs do these days. Best get your firetrucks ready... Just in case the end of times is upon us.

She waved her hands in the air and stressed the 'end of times' bit again, being old and hyperbole-loving— and the fire bit too, voice a tremulous mess such that anything else was difficult to make out. Her eyes were wild, though they had always been wild, and half-ablaze with passion. None trusted her, but it was only polite to entertain facts presented in such a manner. Like hearkening to zealots on the street. If only for seconds.

Town hall representatives conversed amongst themselves and concluded they would most definitely consider a fire warning— but maybe not an end of times, per se. No spring on record, after all, had ever been so warm, and basking in the scaly heat was only pleasing to the few businessmen around. When a businessman says he is satisfied, you know the world's turned on its head.

Later came proposals of what to do; how to fund fire education programs, how to reallocate resources to the fire department, how to evacuate if things really went south. Ah. Perhaps they could go South..?

During the town hall meeting, a cabal of eager newsboys perched in bushes and trees to snoop. They only heard 'end' amidst all the usefulness, and resultantly fixated on 'end'.

The meeting had not yet concluded when a local story titled *The World is Ending and We Must Prepare*, hot off the press, appeared on each and every street corner as if magicked into existence. Even magic hadn't the imagination to come up with such a title. It was uniquely stupid and uniquely mortal.

The World is Ending and We Must Prepare caused much panic. Streets broke out into a frenzied clamour of sweaty, adrenalized bodies, and even those who had the wherewithal to watch their televisions ignored the bits about fire. Heat. Hell. Horrid. Death?

Fatalism crested ashore like a storm-beaten wave, and for the first time in the history of mankind, everyone found purpose in themselves. They found enough purpose to forget that fire foam was an accessible preparatory measure— and town hall members, not at all interested in correcting the papers, hung their hats and joined up.

They would finally see what all the fuss was about; look up from their morning coffee and paperwork and simply do things for the sake of doing things. Put on skirts and dance in the streets. Join a cult, because those seemed quite organised... Or, oh joy, *make one*.

Human rights meant squat to the human mind. It was merely their job to discuss human solutions. And heark, what significance did jobs even hold in the full, sweet hand of judgement? Would someone drag them from the depths whence they came on the basis of resume and resume alone? Impossible.

The City Commissioner adjourned all future meetings. On his office door hung a hastily-scrawled notepad that his employees could not read, though one bright secretary managed to make out 'Join the Church'. Duller secretaries assumed he'd retreated into the arms of Jesus H. Christ (which couldn't have been more wrong).

Digressions and doomsday cults aside, no article-related amendments were made. Sylvia Milne died of a heart attack on the nineteenth of March. Unfortunately, her story was lost to time, and nothing special can be told of a woman clutching her chest.

More can be told, I'd say, of a dog on a hill and boys becoming dogs— and seas and seas as far as the eye will travel. And much more too, for the imagination works wonders.

Dog Boys

Temperatures reached a record high on the twenty-second of March. Jessup and his two friends, whom he called dogs, set out to raid Milne's home— a large, unkempt mansion— and though his idea severely disturbed the dogs, they prided themselves on remaining obsequious no matter what. Butler's dignity.

So on they went, slipping away from household chores (which consisted of fortifying windows with wooden boards and stacking canned soup), and broke through the front door with a crowbar. It took some give, but they managed. Jessup went first, as usual.

They pawed through her business and found little of note. Some unsent cards to relatives down South; a spilled bowl of cat food over the carpeted foyer; and what remained of her breakfast the day before she died. Oatmeal with canned peach slices.

There were many trinkets and objects of ordinary interest, like old candles, paintings, and porcelain animals balanced on the fireplace mantle. Jessup and the dogs were not ordinary boys, and thus ignored them. Besides wanting a spot of fun, they had a goal in mind.

The air smelt awfully like rot. Acrid, almost sweet under all the toxicity, with hints of nonenal and how Jessup expected dead skin to stink after accumulating like peat. He led his dogs away from the main floor and cracked open a red door that presumably led to the

basement; a long, steep stairwell with wallpapered sides. No light switch graced the other side of the doorframe. It was devoid of usual household things, made all the more arcane for its secrecy.

“Maybe she sacrificed kids like us down there,” the large dog piped up.

“Oh, shut your trap,” snapped Jessup. His blonde arm-hairs had begun to rise.

After wriggling around in the darkness for quite some time, someone found the pull cord to a ceiling light and yanked as hard as he could. It flickered once, then twice, then bathed the open space in dim yellowish light— still stuttering intermittently, in line with the bump-bump of the boys’ heartbeats.

To their chagrin, nobody noticed a torture chamber. No human skulls hung from the walls, perpetually-burning incense did not singe their nostrils, and saddest of all, not a spot of evil witchcraft dotted the place. Milne’s basement was plain as her fashion sense and mostly unfinished, with dirty brick walls and awkwardly high ceilings, wooden stabilisers wedged between them and a torn-up mess of dirt, wood, and metal soup. Jessup suggested they avoid getting tetanus, which was easier said than done. Even he was not immune to disease.

“Wait. Guys, guys!”

The small dog, with his penchant for squeezing and slipping, found something besides usual basement fare. He led Jessup and the larger by their hands, cold sweat slathered onto skin like oil— nervous but convinced that this would be his big break; his fifteen minutes of fame in the totality of existence that was here. Now.

Around a tight spot, in the space between two support beams, was a small alcove. Dust blanketed the bare brick walls like a bedsheet; the uncomfortable, too-heavy or too-light sort you’d get in hospice. The air threatened to suffocate them.

Some old wax dishes, likely to hold candles, and photographs, likely to summon someone, rested on the alcove's mantle— made for a fireplace that had never come to fruition. It all looked very occult and very deliberate.

Jessup proclaimed, with the air of a self-important historical reporter, that this was the place where Sylvia Milne had summoned the apocalypse. On a cool February day, before heat and drought set in, she'd made her crotchety way down the stairs, all the while whispering in demon-tongue... And with power borrowed from a primordial evil force, burnt her now-decimated candles to bring about the end of times. Naturally, her heart attack was the price paid.

As Jessup went on, the large dog looked closer at the photographs. He was not prone to scepticism, as scepticism did not gel with his leader's doctrine, but he did enjoy the bit of free thinking he sometimes allowed himself. Like a milkbone. If his eyes worked right, then the images were not *actually* of anything terrifying. No demons and whatnot; no blood-spattered sacrifices either, unless the sole one was...

“Rusty?”

A fat ginger cat who did not like being photographed. *Rest in Peace Rusty*, one label said. *May you catch all the mice of Heaven*, the back of another said. The large dog scratched his chin and wondered whether it was possible to replace the dust coating he'd blown off. Tracing the lumpy curves of Rusty's chin and back, thick as two rolls of good bread, he considered 'accidentally' tearing them up. Jessup would be furious if he spoke outright.

So he yelled outright.

“Ghost! Ghost! Aahh!!”

He also made thumping noises with his own bread-roll legs; enough to terrify the small dog and sufficiently perturb Jessup. Then he tore off and up the stairs, two friends at his heels, and sprinted out the wide-open front door, ending on a cinematic somersault over the front porch. They followed suit, since it looked dangerous. And therefore worth doing.

Panting on the overgrown grass of Sylvia Milne's lawn (after they'd shut and barred her door), Jessup and his dogs concluded that running was for the better. Jessup made the whole thing his idea, of course, and warped the narrative such that he had called "Ghost!" first. Any attempts at protest were wisely shut down. The small dog opened a pack of beef jerky.

"Look at the sky. Look at the *trees*," the large dog said when their excitement wore off, feeling peaceful despite his loss. Grateful that he'd turned a failure into a ghost story.

"Look at the way the trees meet the sky, too. Ain't that beautiful?" He swallowed his last piece of jerky and tossed the bag back to the small dog. Things always worked out.

Jessup suggested they camp there, close to the evil but not close enough for it to hurt them. His dogs naturally agreed, and he set out blankets for each of them. Jessup hated his parents and would hate them until the end of times— and being considerate animals, the dogs agreed with him. Any attempt to avoid Jessup's household was an attempt worth honouring.

7 P.M, his watch-hands ticked. He laid in satisfied silence, poking through only with the occasional comment about Milne, about going back to school the next week, or why the air smelled like burnt marshmallows. And why the end of the world didn't really matter, because they were young and would somehow find themselves stronger after the whole fiasco was over. What doesn't kill you.

That night, the sunset burnt especially bright.

“We’re going to make the most of this experience,” Jessup said, ruffling the little dog’s hair with his hand, “so we’re going to sleep on this good grass tonight. Because why the hell not?”

They went stone-still, breaths coming in shallow pants, intercostals just barely moving as the sky split into bands of purple and orange, then deep blue— a starry needlepoint that was so cool, so refreshing, that neither the dogs nor Jessup could fathom how flames might feel on their skin.

They were fast asleep when the fire tipped over a far-off hill. Bright white lines of heat traced its slope, pushing outward and up like delivered souls. Smoke thickened the air such that walking through it was swimming, and carbon monoxide dreams kept them down, embroiled in nightmares and mystery novels and romances; and death, a fat ginger cat, waiting behind all this.

The small dog dreamed of becoming invisible forever. He weighed the pros and cons of permanent disappearance. The large dog dreamed of soaring above everyone, free to say and do as he wished. Jessup dreamed of punishment.

His dream was unfathomably hot, nerves inflamed like never before; heart a charred black square. All childhood trivialities came to a head, calling him stupid; unworthy; incapable. As leaders do, he woke first.

All around him, for miles and miles, he saw nothing but red. His eyes grew wide, dry tears beading at the corners, but he did not jostle his dogs or scream for them to run. Instead, he laid back down and slept.

Dog Woods

On the twenty-first of March, Talla decided she'd had enough. There were no radios or phones; only televisions that sometimes came in colour and usually did not. The local news channel offered colour to those who had it. She was the entirety of the local news channel.

Besides her, one other program ran; something terribly derivative called "Billy's Playpen", where her milkman, the host, introduced various farm animals to a grainy camera. He ran out of variety after the first six episodes and diversified to plants. How he secured a camera crew and budget for the project, Talla did not know. But what she *did* know was that soon, Billy's Playpen would be the only thing on the picture-box.

As of two days ago, the channel headquarters had half-imploded with news. Strange events regarding the local paper's hottest headline— *The World is Ending...*— popped up like wildfires, including but not limited to: Sylvia Milne's death, a cult, a mayoral ousting, and complaints about streetside preachers offering salvation for five bucks apiece.

Her supervisor, a portly businessman named Kip who hadn't the slightest idea about television, suggested she really ramp up the ante on her coverage. Blow things out of proportion, you know.

Talla politely declined. Folks would appreciate it more, she said, if she continued to monitor the wildfires that nearby counties were reporting. Give some suggestions, tell them to watch out for evacuation notices, you know. Kip threatened to fire her. She threw some acerbic comments his way and left work early. Planning next week's broadcast was ordinarily her job, but she felt no need to plan for chaos. Chaos worked as chaos wished.

That night, stiff as bricks beside a husband she did not love nor want, Talla prayed for cooler weather. His snores, rumbling deep in the pit of his throat, kept her in a state of half-lucidity, and a strange green light rippled through the curtains.

Green. Artificial, chemical green; low-budget martian film green. How funny would it be, she considered with one foot in the wakeful grave, if aliens— who had the entire galaxy to explore— settled on Earth, found themselves disappointed, and left.

The green light waned twelve minutes later. Once rapid eye movement set in, Talla began to dream. She dreamt that, like a determined ruderal, she'd settled on the oil-slicked back of all her flaming baggage and eked out a proper life.

She'd hidden underground, sat perfectly still as everything burnt around her, and grew sparse and wide across the plane after it had gone to ash. And there she remained until the end of time. Just to spite Kip, of course. No better reason than that.

But perhaps conceding instead would prove her maturity; id est, her superiority.

The following morning, Talla ironed her best blouse and packed a suitcase. She would not leave the town, for the town kept a bit of everyone with it, but leaving was not so much a geographical notion as it was an emotional one. Kip accepted her resignation and said nothing, really— just snubbed his cigarette and drew another.

From then on, there was no newscaster.

Factually-inclined individuals made do with dogs and dogwood.

Rat Mothers

The Doctor and her daughter lived in a neat, red brick bungalow. If she was not injecting children with vaccines as they screamed and wriggled and cried for dear life, she was teaching her daughter how to follow proper scientific principles.

Nobody in town really knew about science, she complained. They only listened to what the local paper shat out its rear end, and even then, things were grossly misconstrued. Like a game of broken telephone.

“Don’t be a broken telephone, dear”, The Doctor always reminded her.

On the afternoon of the twentieth, the streets were too warm for hopscotch. The Doctor did not play hopscotch, though— and neither did her daughter, since they followed the same moral doctrine. Ice cubes melting down her neck, The Doctor stood hunched over a metal, black-bottomed tray. What little air came through the window was not enough to cool her. Little pools of sweat collected on her scrubs at the back and armpits.

She appeared quite like a tropical surgeon in wartime, making tinctures out of nothing and cutting off gangrenous limbs with cavalier efficacy. Her daughter ooh-ed and ah-ed. Being a small girl, her topic of interest was not real life. It was more interesting to make mountains out of molehills.

One white rat laid on the tray. Arms rigid at its sides, stiff as if locked in with fear, a steady pool of yellow liquid began dripping from its fur. The Doctor’s daughter groaned,

“More preservative stuff? Where’d that come from?”.

The rat seemed a never-ending source of undrinkable liquid. Formalin, they used in those big rat tubs— but not much. Less than one percent. An ounce of formalin would knock an adult dead.

The Doctor's daughter cut down the rat's midline, only applying pressure at the beginning. Once she'd penetrated its skin, the rest was easy, like cutting wet paper with scissors. Barely any bodily fluids spilled onto the tray. The Doctor commended her for this. Next, she cut two horizontal lines; one at the rat's armpits, and the next above its hind legs. She was now extracting a parasite from an alien on Mars.

The embalming fluid smelt funny, and as she sliced away bits of greyish connective tissue, she considered pretending to faint. Her mother would think it a horrible joke.

Each internal organ sat nicely in place. Enthused to dig up information that wasn't the times tables, her mind sparked synapses that whispered about livers and stomachs and pancreases; useful knowledge if someone needed emergency surgery. Some classmate, or perhaps some man she despised. Perhaps her father.

The liver was a multi-lobed shape that took up surprising real estate. The stomach was tucked slightly behind it, and the pancreas hid even better, but she severed them all and laid their bodies on the black of the tray like fallen enemies' heads.

Finding the small and large intestines proved quite easy; they reminded her of fettuccine. Another cruel joke might entail placing them on a plate and twirling them around her fork. Somewhat disgusted with her own idea, she gagged.

"What's all that talk about the end of times?" She asked innocently, hoping to detract from worse thoughts. The Doctor leaned down, adjusted her daughter's grip on the scalpel,

and brought forth a world-weary sigh that you might expect of a world-weary doctor. It was much too warm for questions.

The last she'd survived a summer so treacherous, she'd been in the pits of hell—where most family physicians were born. Climbing up back then, her bones could take the heat. But now, she doubted herself.

“Useless dross. Some quack published an article about the apocalypse, and everybody's quite literally dying over it... including that old bat. The worst that might happen this week is a wildfire, but we haven't ever had one around here. Nobody notices us. Not even Mother Nature.”

Whistling the chorus to Sweet Caroline, The Doctor took charge and probed through lumps and bumps that interested her. She noticed something colonic, but upon further inspection, it seemed uterine.

Rats possessed bicornuate uteruses to enable large litters. Humans possessed less interesting uteruses to enable single offspring. Her eyes darted to her daughter, and her mind to the singularity—the dumb luck—that had placed her on Earth.

“The newscaster quit yesterday,” she started, snaking around to examine The Doctor's work. “What're you doing over there?”

“Poor Jan, yes, yes... Now we've got a single channel on the picture-box, and it's not in colour either. Damn Billy's Playpen. What a shame.”

The Doctor thought about life and death, as she was apt to whenever unformed babies came her way, and speaking to the child distracted her equally. Before she could tear the scalpel away, her practised hand slipped over the visceral membrane and a noise akin to a

sigh; a gasp; a curse, even; loosed from the rat's flesh. Out fell a pathetic-looking grey embryo, body sliced clean in half.

“...Well, *that's* what I'm doing.”

The Doctor cut her losses and moved onto the next uterine horn, since it was unusual to find only one pup. The atmosphere laid hot and heavy across her brow, almost saturated with ash. When she removed a glove and swiped a hand across, nothing came off. Not even moisture.

The second horn was atrophied, set back in development and size. It had begun to waste away and fade into useless tissue. Whether or not an embryo once existed, there was no question of its death. As good as non-existence.

The Doctor's daughter sensed and mirrored some airborne sadness— but really, she couldn't understand why having one child was all so bad. Or why killing a pregnant rat might be morally reprehensible.

Her girlish conscience soon grew tired. Sloshing bits of shredded organs, flesh, and rib around in the rat's abdominal cavity, she carried the black-bottomed tray to a bucket.

The brain, her mother said, was for next time. And as for the pregnancy,

“It wouldn't have worked out anyway.”

Rat Lovers

On May the 23rd, at the crack of dawn, the great fire came down from the hills and decimated everyone. First it crossed the creek, which had dried to an inch-deep sliver of dilute mud. Then it visited each shop on Main Street, using counters as kindling— and last, it

stopped by the swampland. This all began around 8:00 AM. It was such a sudden event that the day before, nothing seemed unusual.

Some holed themselves in their basements. Others ran the streets, looking up to the sky for solutions; conveniently ignoring any biological predicates of flame. The *idea* of an apocalypse was so perversely attractive that literal, hard proof would destroy all the magic, like the Doctor's daughter and her rats as rats.

Rats were not rats if rats were not deemed rats. Most concluded that the weather was likely a symptom. A little taste, a precursor. No newscaster stood to correct them.

Aside from *some*, *others*, *most*, and *no*, flat-out deniers existed as well. They didn't care much for talk of fires (which had long since burnt out) or apocalypses, and believed quite staunchly that nothing would happen. Either they liked to live in the moment, or they liked to remain calm until proven otherwise.

'Some' made up 5% of the pie chart. 'Others' made up a shocking 20%. 'Most' made up, well, *most*... and 'No' made up one individual, or 0.1%. 0.2% remained due to a zero sum total of evacuators and a two sum total of chimaeras.

Blythe and Leroy might have very well had a lion's head, spines, goat bits, and a snake as a tail, since nobody wanted to come near them. The two old men, one fat and the other skinny—comedic partners banking on the fact of difference—sat on opposite porches and sometimes crossed the street to harass each other.

Other times, they barked over the asphalt or, when nobody was looking, chose a side and played cards, finding more in common than not; finding their younger selves handsome and wondering what may have become of them had they met sooner. Old age, they both said, was a bitter curse. Hell on Earth.

“Crisis actors; all of them. The shooting back down in, ah... Shit... What was it... Whatever state’s under us... That one... Absolute bullshit, don’t you think? The papers mentioned it too many times for it to be real. When you— when you headline something like that, it’s got to have an ulterior motive. Gun control, I’d wager.”

Leroy was not so corpulent in his twenties. In his twenties, he went out to fight. Which war, he couldn’t remember. He couldn’t ring his family either, since they’d all gone somewhere nice and tropical and the only tech store around sold tellies, not radios or dial-phones. Mr. Kip, Leroy surmised, had something to do with that. Him and his insidious monopoly over information.

Tossing an out-of-press coin, he added, “What say you?”

“Heads. The world’s ending, Leroy; don’t imagine we gotta care about crisis actors in another state. We gotta care about the crisis actors in *ours*.”

Leroy uncovered the coin. The head of a Roman-looking man stared at something far-off, equally Roman-looking text curved around it. Damn Blythe and his horrid powers of divination. And his stick legs and stick arms, and the funny way he would appear in a stick coffin. Leroy blinked once, then twice, then shook death from his shoulders.

“Suppose you’re right. The fire nonsense was a cover-up, obviously, and the real news came out and shocked everyone. But we ain’t shocked because... We ain’t made of the same stuff. And I bet even now they haven’t told us the half of it.

We don’t have no dates or anything. Where the hell did the dates go? If there’s an apocalypse, there’s always a calendar. So God knows when to bring hellfire upon us.”

Blythe nodded sagely and added, “Might not be too bad anyway. We might just hop on the express to heaven. I’ve seen worse, back in my day... I can handle whatever. Seen men drop like flies, all bloodied and that, and seen our schools teach Marxism to the kids—watched the government pretend the world is round.”

The coin rose again, and like a bird with clipped wings, fell clattering to the table. It wasn’t a good flip. Heads again.

“I’ve seen worse than you’ve seen.”

“Oh no, you haven’t.”

Each spoke in their own language, ignorant of the other party. The whole event was a competition between self and truth, not he and he. They soon lapsed into a dialogue of all the wild things they’d encountered in their lives. Neither party could speak to the veracity of each statement, for they’d only met ten years ago, but Leroy flipped the Roman-looking coin every time he clocked a possibly-false bit. Just to keep score.

“Heads, damn it. Now, I’ve seen a baby born with nothin’ but one leg and one arm. One eye, too. They had to toss him in the creek.”

“Heads again? It’ll be tails next time. Well, *I’ve* seen a good country girl possessed by a demon. Had to bring in the exorcist and that, since she was crawling all over the walls—and when I came to deliver some milk, she started hissing like mad.”

“Heads. Ha.”

As conspiracy theorists were prone to do, Blythe and Leroy inserted little needle-lengths of propaganda into their stories. Good, manly men like them loved to talk about demons and races, for He did not make everyone perfect, and some group had to have

been hastily penned at the last minute. And women, too. And aliens, because dipping into those was much like dipping into academics; good in moderation.

“Heads,” sighed Leroy. In the shade, his face was a wrinkled prune.

“Gimme that.”

Blythe, dissatisfied with the conversation’s progress, thought up something smart to say next. He thumbed the foreign coin and said it was very likely that they were living in a simulation *run* by aliens— so every few years, those aliens would descend to observe them. They would look like bugs, since modern depictions of green humans were simply wrong, and shapeshift into politicians and whatnot. Which was more interesting than the whole lizard-person spiel Leroy had gone on earlier.

Leroy snatched the coin from Blythe’s hands.

“It’s too damn hot out, today. Don’t get your sweat all over my coin. No business taking my stuff either, acting all high and mighty, especially when you ain’t got any proof of it. I got proof of mine, but what do *you* know about them bug-aliens?”

Being conspiracy theorists, the whole notion of proof seemed quite absurd to Blythe. He chalked the man’s sudden insistence up to old age and vitriol; jealousy that he could not come up with such convincing stories.

The world was about to end soon, if all went according to Providential plans. Blythe, for the first time in a long time, did not think the basic facts of that matter were wrong. He could feel the end in the tips of his rheumatoid toes and sense the heat in the air. Some primal part of him even screamed “fire warning”, but he ignored it.

All he said, placing his chips on the table, was this:

“Look up, Leroy.”

Up.

Up there, Leroy could see the beginnings of an ashen sunrise, but the sky still hadn't left its blanket. The sun, burning red, peeked far off in the distance and would not come to them for some time. They had an hour left. He squinted and polished his monocle. Stars still dotted the sky, including but not limited to the meditative morning star.

He appreciated Sirius' stillness; slightly askew, obviously natural. Whatever was bearing down on them now, growing brighter than even the planets, followed an *unnatural* order. And soon covered every pinprick in sight.

At first he'd brushed it off as an astronomical event— a turn of luck on Blythe's end— but when the star-adjacent shape continued its descent, sending soft hums through the air, he knew that perhaps something was amiss. The hair on his arms rose, and wind knocked his monocle askew. Then the hums became mechanical whirs, resounding louder and louder with each passing second; sending the two men back in their porch chairs, glued to the cedar.

Blythe, despite finding it very difficult to breathe, let out a reserve of air he'd held for miracles such as this, and expelled the fullest, sweetest tide his old lungs could muster. He watched expectantly as the alien shape (not at all like a saucer, more of a two-pronged thing, like a rat uterus) descended upon them, settling in their front lawn. Nobody would believe them. Nobody ever *did* believe them.

Grass tore away from its roots and flew every which way from the force of impact. It appeared deliberate, landing with a big bang to alert everyone, that sort of strategy— but then again, aliens did not think like regular people. A small sonic boom knocked Leroy and Blythe back in their seats again; right when they'd gotten up dazed.

Frozen once more, awe-filled and god-fearing and far beyond conspiracy, their eyes burned to catalogue each detail; carved metal siding, little bits and baubles, a black, glassy dome situated between both prongs; its thrusters pulsing green, bathing the whole ship in oppressive light. Cheap light, at second glance. Martian movie green. Fake radioactive goop green. Blythe was a tad disappointed about the shade, but didn't let on.

The glassy dome popped open with a neat hiss. Two rat-like figures — whose cladistic relation to rats was questionable at best— left their seats. They skittered over the grass as if it burned them, taking quick steps until asphalt met their paws, at which point they calmed down considerably and began squeaking to one another.

Squeak, squeak, squeak, one wearing a skimpy jumpsuit proposed, followed by *squeak, squeak, squeak, sigh* from the other, a more austere clad grey alien. On two legs, they ambled over to Blythe and Leroy's porch, long, rattish smiles (that looked more like yawns) stretching the skin of their mouths.

"Are you gonna talk to those things?" Leroy whispered.

"Wait and see what they've got to say for themselves."

Austere, the sun crept up. She inched higher in the sky with each passing moment, drawing back the veil of night like a burlesque dancer -- teasing, teasing, the fire to come. It was already too hot and too burnt for morning.

"Good day," The skimpy rat started. Blythe swore he saw them holding back laughter. They cleared their throat about seven times, bent down and turned around huffing, then finally stood straight to add, "I mean, hey. *Hey*."

Their voice was high-pitched and ugly, and upon closer glance, they had no ears. A bit like a furry bowling pin. It seemed thoroughly unusual that they might think of *humans* as funny, so Blythe kept the idea to himself. Beauty standards were subjective, but not that subjective. And old men were not known to change. Goths, punks, creatures of the night all operated in the same abnormal fashion. Now, rat-aliens.

“You,” said Blythe. “What’re you doing in my yard? What *are* you in the first place?”

This time the austere rat spoke, and the sound of nails on a chalkboard came with their words. They shuffled from side to side nervously, which made the whole encounter a bit less intimidating— but it looked like they were holding in giggles as well.

“We are tourists. I mean... Oh, I can’t say that, haha... What do I say again? We are aliens and we want to see your... Your leader.”

The skimpy rat clouted them over the head, clarifying,

“We want to see your leader, yes. Or else we’ll decimate everything you hold dear; including your husband-thing. The other man. The silent one. Is he mute?”

Leroy took offence and shook his head, but soon realised that shaking his head did not at all disprove the point of muteness. He wondered how his stringy life had trailed along to this one event and felt a deep impression, as if stamped, settle into his chest. He dreaded that the impression would somehow grow deeper and subsume him whole, or turn him inside out and bare his wrinkled organs for all to see. The smoke settled.

“Leroy, tell him you’re not my husband. *Leroy*.”

“ ... ”

It suddenly struck him that they would disappear very soon. He saw events roll at his feet— them choking on their own spit, seeing the end times cresting over the hill— but in totally preventable fashion as they muttered old-man sayings. The dawn was red and would grow redder, so much so that their front yard would turn to a Christmas tree.

The only question was this: Did he want to disappear now or then? The time he'd spent on Earth had been, as mentioned before, stringy. Not of substance. He'd never married, apart from that one fling, and his family had spread out thin like rationed butter. And conspiracy theories were the pools from which he drank. The rules by which he stuck.

"Old age is a bitter curse. Hell on Earth," Leroy muttered to no one in particular.

Blythe had his moods too, but none so bad as this degenerative spell. He didn't want to disappear at all; there were vegetable gardens to plant and people to forgive. The local paper would have a field day with his testimony, since they no longer upheld journalistic standards. Last he'd heard, they'd been completely taken over.

"Listen up." He took charge. "If you don't tell us the truth, we'll... *decimate*... you first. I don't see no weapons on you, but I've got a shotgun out back. Shotguns kill vermin."

During the long pauses between these statements, rats one and two squeaked amongst themselves. Now that the sun had come over fully, there was no sunrise at all— only towers of smoke and clouds of orange-red flame. They didn't want to linger for long. There were plenty more locations on their disaster tourists' guide. Stupid Page 97 cited 'Random Coordinate Generator' as a fun, risky idea for a couples' rendezvous... And look where it had gotten them. Right in the path of the disaster!

"Well," the skimpy rat sighed, switching to standard English, "it should be getting *quite* hard to breathe in about ten minutes. Look over those hills! Isn't that a marvel?"

With much difficulty, Leroy and Blythe extricated the fire's effects from the spaceship's effects. Strange smell; strange heat; shortness of breath. Smoky skies. Alien spaceships gave off no emissions, for they ran on electricity.

“Well, well, well. It should be getting quite hard to breathe in about nine minutes. Look, Gladar, isn't that romantic? Isn't that a marvel?”

Blythe grabbed onto Leroy's wrist, shrivelled skin meeting shrivelled skin, as the rat met their presumed partner. This was comedic. This shouldn't have been so comedic. One short, one tall— one scantily clad, the other covered from head to toe— all together, watching the world burn. To their collective joy, no ambulances or firetrucks sounded in the distance, and neighbours, waking from uneasy sleep, did little other than scream and groan.

After some time, the rats hopped back into their spaceship and bade the conspiracy theorists goodbye. They apologised for staying so late, to which Blythe replied it was actually early, and jetted away, leaving blown grass and hard winds in their wake. He conversed in a civil, low-voiced manner with Leroy, who had recovered.

“Neighbours have it right. The screaming ones are crisis actors— look at 'em go! Whew. Suppose the fire isn't even real, eh... Rats might be realer. You were wrong about the bug-alien bit in the end, but I can't hold you to anything.”

“My eyesight's bad. Rats, lizards, what... They all look the same.”

“Oh, yeah. All tiny little things... Except *those* ones were large. Anyway, I wouldn't mind dying too much if it was with you. Not to say that we're about to die, crisis actors and all, but y'know. In the event.”

Nine minutes had not yet passed, but breathing was already a laborious task. Flames danced over the hill like fairy lamps, and their eyes filled with the afterglow of lit grass. Certifications, names, theories, and aliens had nothing to do with the fact of the matter.

“I wouldn’t mind either, Leroy. I wouldn’t.”

Tar Srevol

On the eighteenth of March, although it had likely begun earlier, an angry group of ‘concerned citizens’ stormed and occupied the town hall— which also served as a courthouse and a tea room. They later took the news building, but some cult (named the Church of Final Foundation) stole that one.

What had once stood demurely, like a young Southern belle at her first county fair— legs crossed, drawing attention in that she did not seek to— now cut a striking figure against the smoke-grey ether. Various painted banners and flags stuck at odd ends, one especially large roll of paper pasted over the entrance archway. *Down With the Government*.

The windows were covered with cardboard; the clock tower defiled in every way imaginable. By that, it would be more apt to say the original machine was removed and replaced with somebody’s pinup girl clock, then doused in the same blood-red paint that Mayor Clarkson went to the grave with, then removed and replaced with another clock.

Oh, yes. More importantly, Mayor Clarkson was dead. They’d killed him; Jessup’s loving, paranoid parents. Jos and Jan, both short for unknowns, decided that doomsday prepping had gotten boring, so they joined up the cause, hearing of a very romantic European coup taking place. Doffing their tinfoil hats and wearable canned-food cartons, they drove to the town hall and went to take a look.

There was no parking. Buicks and Chevrolets lined the main road, bumper to bumper. Pressed against each other in lovers' fashion. Besides that, there appeared to be no 'romantic' edge. Jos and Jan met scruffy farmers from out of town, familiar faces from the school's Parental Council, and some small business owners crowded around the hall's entrance, screeching into megaphones. But no fun third.

Confronted with this, Jos wondered how much of it was about the End of Times and how much of it was about the desire to hear one's own voice amplified. Reflected by the masses, swirling about like mice in a trap, so embroiled in their egos that right and wrong became mere symbols.

Jan took her hand. They went forth and parted the crowd biblically. As they moved, Jos wondered what Jessup was getting up to these days. Little boys, little boys. Those monsters. Little boys were God-sent tests, if she did say so herself. Nobody would willingly accept one if they knew what the care and keeping of such creatures entailed. Jessup was safe. Jessup knew how to keep himself alive. And he knew better than breaking into homes.

The town hall, once again equivalent to (and also serving as) a courthouse, was almost empty. Benches met them head-on, but did not hold any onlookers. Jury tables appeared unpopulated, unless by ghosts.

Perfect symmetry haunted the room, down to the two national flags on either side of the judge's desk. Down to the portraits of old, sallow men and flaccid hanging lights. Down to either side of Mayor Clarkson's world-weary face as he regarded them from his seat. He held no gavel, and his authority seemed less absolute than gone.

"It's hot in here," Jan pointed out. "I don't get why they're all standing outside. Why haven't they gone in yet?"

Over the course of his four-year term, Mayor Clarkson had aged considerably. He'd come into the job all perky and wrinkle-free, but he'd come to the end, this, with hollows in his eyes and crows' feet upon his crow's legs. Politics ruined the spirit; made juice of it.

Watching Jos and Jan, he realised he hadn't married or had any children— or even thought of continuing his bloodline, for the town was effectively his— but the town wasn't his, really. The town was a blood-sucking parasite that cut lines short.

Clarkson knew their son, Jessup. Jessup bothered his constables, and sometimes tortured rats for fun. Industrious child, but very disturbed. Would gather buckets full of dead vermin, freeze them, and sell them for 'educational purposes' under fake company names like RatCorp, Scientific Deliveries Incorporated, Big J Shipping and Handling, and Supjes Laboratories.

"Did you know that your son is a criminal?" The mayor broached, turning the tables. He hadn't the slightest clue why none of the protestors wanted to come in, since he was right there and frankly getting bored of being right there.

"I'm the one asking the questions here."

Jan fumbled in his pockets for a moment. He pointed a Beretta M1951 at the mayor's bald head. Jos brandished a kitchen knife hidden in the lining of her dress. Doomsday prepping brought forth all the ugliness and strength that humanity had to offer; nobody would believe they'd once been real estate agents.

"Tell me what your insidious goals are, and why the world is about to end," he started.

"Oh, and tell me what your government's been hiding."

"You love your son, don't you?"

Jos nodded emphatically. Jan readied his aiming hand; the left one. Politicians never answered questions straight. They always beat around the bush, clawing at ad hominem attacks. They relinquished the title of ‘ordinary person’ as soon as civil responsibility came over their heads.

“Jessup has nothing to do with this. Jessup is at home, safe. He’s in our basement waiting for the world to end, because we’ve raised him right. What are you doing for your people, Mayor Clarkson? What are you doing for the town and the county and the hundreds of confused individuals wondering when Armageddon’ll happen? How it’ll happen?”

All very difficult questions. Mayor Clarkson wasn’t sure how to explain that Armageddon did not exist, he frankly did not believe in God, and this entire situation was borne of misinformation. Disinformation. Whatever those words meant. Stupid Sylvia Milne and her hyperbole— and even stupider news boys and their penchants for drama.

“*Ah*. I...”

See, he would have left the courthouse and followed his employees, but he didn’t enjoy following cults or religions or anything like that. He only wanted a vacation. And now a gun was at his head, whispering sedition and salt to the wound of sloth.

“I mean, you probably wouldn’t understand. You probably... No, I don’t mean that. I’m sure you could understand if you put your mind to it, but you both look a little psychotic, no offence meant, and I’m also a little scared-

And *do* you love your son?”

Jan checked the Beretta for bullets. There were spares in his coat pocket, if need be. Killing someone was only difficult in theory, he surmised. Any barrier to the act was artificial, set in place by law alone.

“Tell us the truth, Clarkson!” Jos snapped. “Tell us the truth or my husband will blow a hole through your brain! I’ll lick it up, Clarkson! I’ll lick up your brain paste!”

Jan gestured for her to tone it down a little. He pointed to her, twirled his index finger, and mouthed ‘cuckoo’. She sounded awfully like those conspiracy theorist geezers down the road; a cadence that did not reflect well on either of them.

“Sorry. I mean, I’ll give you a good Christian burial. But you’ll go to hell anyway. Your duty is to help your people; not let them run about like headless chickens, sieging your buildings. There’s a cult running the streets, and they’re bothering everyone! Even worse, the police are running the cult!”

“The police haven’t gotten to run things for a while,” the mayor pointed out.

He was nearing the end of his mayoral term according to written law, but quite honestly felt younger than ever. Like a phoenix. Caw. If a fire broke out and razed the town to ash, there would be no firetrucks to calm the heat. There would be no news anchor to relay the information, and no businessman to sell his televisions... and no dogs, who knew what was survivable and what was not.

See, he *wanted* to pray for his peoples’ safety, for their precautionary skills— which would do more than holing up in the courthouse. He just couldn’t find the faith. Whatever laid dead in the recesses of his thoracic cavity was not a heart. It wanted death, and may have been a demon.

About twenty metres from the courthouse, voices began to chorus, “Down With the Government! Down With the Government!” Their syncopated rhythm set him swaying about, relishing in the fact that they did not know his name. The world, he concluded, would not end unless someone did something stupid. Large-scale tragedies were almost always anthropogenic; not really tragedies otherwise, merely facts of life.

“Anyway,” said the mayor, “Do you love your son? He calls himself Jessup these days. And he runs with two little boys named Thomas and Pavi, but they’ve taken to becoming dogs. Dogs are roaming the roads. Jessup is roaming the roads.”

Jan stared into his eyes thoughtfully, heavy with consideration, but said nothing in response. Jos pressed closer. Her weight tied him to the wooden planks. They’d never been good at parenting.

“Our son is doing the best he can. We... We appreciate him very much. He’s a straight-A student at school. His friends... They’re just playing around. As boys do.”

“But do you love him?”

Staring straight into the mouth of Jan’s beretta, the mayor remained staunch and steady. He felt the hard bottom of his seat, justice being uncomfortable, and wondered whether Jan actually knew how to shoot. Death would deliver him from a zero-sum game. Culpability never rested on the shoulders of the dead; relatives collected debts.

They did not know his name.

“Do you love your son, Jocelyn and Jonathan Jones?”

Jan (Jonathan, as born) readied his arm and aimed straight at the mayor’s head. He sat perfectly still, for ease of fire. The bullet was medicine, though a hard pill to swallow.

Before he dropped, several scenes ghosted his mind:

Cans, tin cans. Thousands of clanging tin cans, held by protestors or other difficult parties. They always messed with cans, first outside the head— now inside. Also, little boys and dogs. Also, Jan's weary sigh upon impact, as if he'd been shot himself.

He saw a dog on a hill, and dogs in a yard, and a fire that didn't have to happen, and the entire world as a town burning, burning, burning.

Then his body parted ways with his mind and it was all alright.

Peaceful only in death, Jos and Jan spent some time appreciating his corpse. He'd done a lot for the town in his prime, but evidently armageddon necessitated anarchy. They felt quite like divine messengers. The longer they stood, the more blood pooled and coagulated below him, and soon the entire courthouse smelled of iron.

Jos and Jan stole the flags from behind his desk and covered him such that he became a fallen ghost; one under, one over. With effort and time, they managed to drag his body along the length of the floor and haul it out the door. Jos shrieked for everyone to make way, make way, get the Hell out of the way unless you want a bullet between your eyes—

They clapped like rabble-rousing primary schoolers. Jos and Jan lowered him respectfully down the stairs, topmost sheet jiggling with each bump, and placed him on the front lawn where everyone could watch. There wasn't much else to do.

Jan thought it best to pack up and leave, maybe revisit doomsday prepping. He cleaned his Beretta with a handkerchief, feet dragging more than usual; on the sidewalk, later on the gas pedal past red lights.

He'd gotten assassin-sick; too used to all the blood and gore, absent of worldly ties such that life no longer pleased him as much as its cession. Life never pleased him much anyway, besides the bits with Jos in them, which were tolerable at best. Jos felt the same. The middle-meeting arrangement they had was most auspicious.

"He calls himself Jessup these days, does he?" Said Jan, after discussing how they'd need to catch up on their doomsday prepping and get back on time for lunch. The wheel was cold, hard leather on his hands, and the dogs were quiet outside. Gone.

"I don't remember what we named him. It wasn't Jessup, though," Jos replied.

One of them, both of them, wanted to say more— but they kept their mouths shut for fear of the mayor's vengeful ghost. In truth, this fear was misguided. He would have preferred them discussing Jessup some more. Maybe, if they raised his name enough times, it would raise his body. Like a proper son.

Revol Tar

On the seventh day, God 2 removed their name and identity and made the Church of Final Foundation.

God 2 was once a police-person named C. Saban. C. Saban patrolled the streets and did police-related things, presumably, but nobody checked them on it. In accordance with the slip and slide of time, nobody questioned their subsequent religious influence.

The first step to controlling the world was naming the *new* world. They'd named themselves Saban after several strange dreams about a cat and a pigtailed girl who owned some sort of surrealist cafe, but naming an organisation was an entirely different beast. The Church of ____ obviously. The Church of what? The Church of the End of Times? Too many

‘ofs’ would ruin the flow. The Church of Final (last, apocalyptic, very neue). The Church of Final— now the kicker, the stable ending to tie in a point of credibility...

Foundation. Steady, rock-hard foundations. Those who wore their hands would appreciate the name, as dependable and country as it was avant-garde and communist.

On the eighth day, the firemen joined the Church. Service officials flocked to C. Saban like flies to a honeypot, and they brought with them trucks and great hoses. In light of recent raids and green lights, they could not donate every truck to the cause— but more were promised, along with donations and typical cultish offerings (legs, arms, hearts, intimacy).

Everybody is an incipient cultist, said Saban; one must only let oneself fall into the lull of proper leadership and correctment if one seeks to really, ah, become devoted for good. Speaking in prophetic manner usually helps with the ‘proper leadership’ bit, as per Aristotle’s advice.

On the eighth day Saban *also* proclaimed, “Here lies our headquarters.” Their followers had just ransacked the local paper and rearranged its desks. Removing the printing press workers was somewhat difficult, so they conceded and converted them instead.

The philosophical ‘foundation’ of the Church, which seemed to apply to most (if not all) rational thinkers, was built on the following postulates/rules:

1. The Church has existed all along in one’s mind. One wanted the Church, whether one was religious or not, and one’s seeking behaviour prevented one from attaining true happiness. Saban will deliver one to enlightenment if one so desires.
2. Whatever comes to one, one must take it. Remaining stoic in the face of destruction is a sign of a true warrior, and the stronger one is, the more likely one is to become enlightened.

3. One must not listen to any news sources or ‘Outies’; what the Church colloquially calls outsiders.
4. One must meditate four times every day, for four is the number of death and death is what one seeks. Death is enlightenment, as a matter of fact, and humans want to ground themselves— find the ground in proximity— so that they might return to the most basic state. This is why they enjoy sex. They become a more animalistic self and revisit their means of creation, rebelling against it... towards futile ends.
5. One must NOT have sex in the news building. Please.
6. Any dreams one has should be flagged as prophetic and reported to Church Leader Saban, unless they contain inappropriate or incriminating content. Keep them private in that case.
7. Regarding God and whether God exists, let’s just say that God is all around. God is an intrinsically evil being who traps mortals in the coil. She seeks human suffering but not human removal from suffering, and to rebel against her properly, mortals must abandon all instincts of survival. Life is torture.
8. Self-inflicted death, however, is OFF LIMITS! Ruminating on possible avenues of death is exactly what God wants— because it brings one to Hell, which maximises the soul’s overall suffering. If one ends up in Heaven, which should occur if one lives a virtuous life (even while refusing to fight for one’s own survival), then one has successfully spited Her.
9. Saban doesn’t mind being called ‘God 2’, because their overarching goal involves the violent takeover of Heaven (when they and their followers become enlightened and find the gateway).

So it was all sort of difficult and very scattered. In accordance with Saban’s arbitrary goal-setting practices, new rules popped up here and there and sometimes stayed. The main

tenets were better paraphrased as, “Death is good, but don’t kill yourself. Instead, float in a limbo of survival until the end of times comes— at which point you must simply exist and *appreciate* the suffering that God has tried to inflict on you. In doing so, you will spite Her and become enlightened.” Supposedly nihilism but better; with purpose and a strong, concrete backbone rooted in the foundations of the news building.

Saban’s first cult member was a strange fellow. He only spoke gibberish; strings of individually coherent words that could not rise beyond the sum of their parts, like “Moon eclipse spectacle falls furtive facetious the will of will of swill swine pine dine round house fine time proposal create propose review write for self for it and then if you poor sometimes when if go says nay to wind.”

Saban replied, “And we will accept you as you are.”

The two became fast friends and set out to recruit others. Saban, well-acquainted with the police force, rounded up their old comrades and brought them all to their peeling brick fortress, tall as a man-made mountain would ever stand. It was not particularly difficult; recruiting friends. Saban’s stratagem involved first discussing old times and older trauma— next gradually poking their head into serious topics like the next presidential election— last, after planting their feet on common ground, suggesting a way out of chaos. Since chaos reigned. Despotism reigned.

On the tenth day, March 21st, Saban found themselves a B.O.D. Running the food raids was gibberish man (who admitted his lack of direction in life and henceforth pledged himself to Saban’s godly sovereignty); handling the propaganda was a rebellious young missus who would have done numbers in Hollywood, but called the place a black hole; and last but not least, generating the ideas was somebody named Passenger. Passenger let on their

scepticism and avoided prayer when possible— and nobody, not even Saban, was sure of where they'd come from. But they made good use of themselves, so Saban didn't mind.

Cults, Passenger suggested, needed mystery. Quiet, covert charisma. Saban agreed, and implemented a “no-speak” policy. The Church of Final Foundation existed only in whispers from then on. The hottest new fad, but how could you get in? How could you break through the impenetrable news building's doors and pledge allegiance?

Rumours began to spread, as rumours did when secrecy abounded. The Church's influence was a passage of vibrant warms singing the treetops and raining char, slowly but surely eclipsing the sun. Soon, the entire city council fell under their thumb. Children spread flyers from the rooftops as they called— *heark, snow, it's snowing*— in their bell-clear voices, and defeatism seemed the only way to live.

Passenger sewed velvet robes for Church members. They also (symbolically) began daily exchanges in which members drank each others' sweat. During afternoons they prowled the streets while Saban stood atop their besieged land, presiding over the lower things.

Up there, Saban could see the past, present, and future. Passenger joined them silently. Hollywood Woman proposed aesthetic fundamentals. Gibberish Man supported the Church with loud, booming proclamations. They all liaised around a little fold-up table and sipped instant tea and coffee.

Conversationally, Passenger began with the usual fare; how their operations had been going, budget details and whatnot, and also expansion plans in the short time that remained. Hollywood Woman played with her golden bangles and Gibberish Man nodded at everything; both seemingly bored. Saban wondered whether the end of times would come soon, and if so, whether they'd perk up a bit. Organising their cult was simple business at first, but the

ongoing logistics of it were tricky and best left to Passenger, who had no use reporting back. Saban told Passenger to keep crunching numbers. Or something. Keep doing what you do. And Passenger rested their chin on tented hands— gaze fixed on a point in the near distance— over the bungalows, over the single main street, over the counties and flat Earth and the paradigm of belief.

They asked the group, mostly directed at Saban themselves, “Is waiting our craft?”

“Yes, Passenger. Waiting is our craft, for we must remain stoic in the face of imminent destruction. Observe all the crazies below us... boarding up their homes, fraught with peril as they grow half-insane from the wait... the weight. Unlike them, we embrace the weight. That is our core philosophy, all cultish customs mere embellishments.”

Gibberish Man added, “All rules are mere guidelines for wayward sheep. The bits about female God and sex in news buildings don’t mean much; they add appeal. And you, sceptic as you are.. Your questions hold no weight in the face of our supreme God 2.”

Hollywood Woman traced the lines on Saban’s face. She couldn’t place their origin, and taking any average of their skin tone yielded a muddied greenish-bluish-red. Like sloshing paint together.

“But it’s not scary at all? Consigning yourself to the long haul while others celebrate their lives? I mean, arguably— if the point of this is to avoid suffering, we’re merely drawing it out. Another issue; there is God, and She enjoys suffering, but for some bizarre reason She has created Heaven. Either Heaven yields suffering as well, or perhaps she does not enjoy it as much as our church proclaims.”

While Passenger went on, Saban meditated.

“Perhaps she feels obligated to provide an alternative to Hell, though, paralleling our embellishments to the rules and whatnot. Which I completely understand, but none of this negates our lack of commitment to the semantic— my point being that you don’t know what you’re doing, and we don’t know what we’re doing, and you haven’t read a bit of anything in your entire life. Because you, Saban, are an ex-constable in the throes of middle age and I, Passenger, am not meant to be here.”

See, the difficult thing about letting someone powerful into an organisation *was* their power. The Church of Final Foundation would not have run smoothly without Passenger, but Passenger also threatened Saban’s authority. Saban knew little about themselves, having emptied their soul of important characteristics. They had the impression that Passenger knew more— somehow held onto those characteristics, grabbed them before floating away— with an intimate window into their deepest, darkest prodromal God-syndrome thoughts.

“What do you suggest we do, then? If you’re so high and mighty, *Passenger*? We have three hundred members and they seem perfectly content with the running of things.”

“I suggest you remember what fear means, *Saban*. Remember what you might have been before being became.”

Passenger, bolder than ever, leaned over the table and nearly met Saban’s forehead. Hollywood Woman and Gibberish man made no corrective movements. They were a bit terrified, what with Passenger’s glowing eyes and hair whipping from side to side. Hollywood Woman, paint on the mind, mixed startling ceruleans.

Saban couldn’t remember what they were before... before being became, or whatever that meant. Besides patrolling streets, avoiding cracks for fear of breaking someone’s back.

Slowly but surely, they edged away from Passenger's divine form and made their way to another, less metaphorical end. Anti-suicide nets lined the news building's rooftops, as per their previous instruction— but there was a chink in the armour; a gap about six feet wide where birds had pecked through the netting. Initially they'd set out to control Earth, and then their tenets became more philosophical; more... difficult to pin down such that onlookers might catch the shining show and sign their lives away. Cultishness was as for-profit as the Red Cross.

The end of times was upon them, Saban thought on rote; over, over, and over again, Passenger humming behind their back. And they didn't believe in God, and maybe everything had blown out of proportion, and mostly they remembered being scared. Scared like a small child, bones peeking, heart in all the wrong places. Every gust of wind was a predator, everything alone was a dirtiness waiting to consume. Entering the police force, they'd passed their exams with flying colours— and still, fear hung around.

Starting the Church of Final Foundation, they'd read business manuals and leveraged their influence. Breezed past the enjoyable journey of aspiring to success, drawing out this moment alone for the same reason as all movement occurred. Fear. Fear; the primal nerve-twinge made spiritual. They dreamt of cats and pigtailed girls and behind it all, fear. Being scared, being, before being became. Because emotion was woven into the universe with care and the intent of keeping.

Self-inflicted death, however, is OFF LIMITS! Ruminating on possible avenues of death is exactly what God wants for it brings one to Hell, which maximises the soul's overall suffering. If one ends up in Heaven, which should occur if one lives a virtuous life (even while refusing to fight for one's own survival), then one has successfully spited Her.

Cult leaders always lost their minds eventually. They were either ill and believed in their ideas until death from radicalization, or became ill by force of habit. Yes, it was all difficult. And scattered.

“I don’t want to wait any longer,” said Saban. A child spoke through them.

“I’m scared and I don’t want to wait any longer.”

Passenger cooed supportively. Hollywood Woman and Gibberish Man watched in stunned silence, for their backs were not turned to the thing that Passenger had then become— best described as blinding, unforgettable; burning. Not fire, but close.

“Come, then. *Don’t* wait. The Church always exists in one’s mind. It has always existed. You’ve been looking all this time.”

Below, shoals of protestors and cult members shot at each other with guns, and the corpse of a man that may have been the Mayor lay on the nearby courthouse green. Pale and tired.

Passenger hovered towards their second god, holding the others in place. Saban needed no encouragement to slowly shift their weight— from the heels to the toes to nothing at all— until the air took them, and they too became flame.

Pentatonic

The end is oft painted by artists;

Those without a part in

Plans of war but a

Keen eye for beauty

And things unseen

Today a wolf-shape sleeps in shadow

White and sheepish

Blood runs the streets red

Past portents of doom and

Apocalyptic nonsense

I listen carefully; the earth hums

Bodies rise

From their graves with

Bony, outstretched arms

To germinate 'midst fire and brimstone

Despite my fear, I lend an ear

The

A... Damn it.

On the Ides of March, the poet hung their head in despair. Writing about something that hadn't happened yet was difficult. Some part of them wanted all the theories to take root in truth, though they severely doubted their credibility. They were a bad poet, because they could not let arms do what arms did best. The light would later claim their arms and gaping mouth, heat-dried in a horrified circle, after flying too close.

Minor

"That one's a monster."

"A monster? No, no— it's a heron. Look at the neck, dude. Monsters don't exist."

One day, some day, all day, Morie and Antoine sat watching the clouds over the marsh. It was a good ways away from the town, about an hour's drive, but Antoine insisted she take him once every week— even after the marsh had cracked into dusty brown pieces. No rain had graced the banks in quite some time, and the reeds hung flaccid on either side of the boardwalk.

“Maybe the monster's looking for food,” Antoine suggested. He was a catty sort of child, the sort that Morie hated babysitting, but his parents paid well. Occasionally he said something endearing, after which she would tousle his hair and laugh. They seldom understood one another. Each exchange was a lesson in translation.

“Heron. *That's* because it's dry as sin. Or because the world's gonna end tomorrow.” Morie popped her gum with a satisfied crack. Being fifteen years old, she had the impression that she knew more, and better, than whatever Antoine could acquire in nine.

Back when the weather was wet and tasty, Antoine loved spending entire days at the marshlands' behest; capturing wayward frogs and skipping stones over the small half-ponds that bloomed whenever it rained. He also held funerals for dead squirrels and marsh coyotes; especially those who made Faustian bargains, because he could appreciate their exercises of mortality. Faust made him laugh, just like Munsch made him scream.

“Heron, monster, who cares.. Stop spoiling my fun!

If I say it's a monster, it's a monster.”

Morie smiled tightly and said no more. She kicked at bits of old wood sagging from the boardwalk. Maybe one day she'd hit a living thing, and the living thing would curse her forever, and maybe it was Antoine wishing misfortune upon her. Yes, it was Antoine.

Antoine thought silently as he moved along— Morie far ahead, head full of how she might have fun before times ended for good. Money would hold no value after the apocalypse— but she didn't want to take her chances in the event that nothing happened, and thus continued to babysit Antoine. One more hour of supervision would earn her a cold coffee.

Back when adults weren't half as stupid, Antoine loved analysing their behaviours and customs. Sandals striking the boardwalk with catlike facility, he kept himself busy, factoring the 'apocalypse' into his theories. Obviously, the entire scare had come from Sylvia Milne and her speech at the city-hall-courthouse-thing, but she'd never *confirmed* a world-ending event. She'd merely warned officials that the dry conditions might necessitate fire prep. How one thing came to another was confusing. Antoine was confused.

And now everyone believed the sensation. And everyone claimed godhood. Everyone also saw aliens, but he believed that bit because counterclaims were falsifiable.

So, adults. *Adults*.

Children lacked in several departments; undeveloped prefrontal cortexes, undeveloped heights, undeveloped empathy centres. Adults, however, had no excuse to lack anything. The genre of 'smart child proving dumb adult wrong' was overdone, that he would admit. Still, grains of truth sifted into his life.

Oftentimes, adults weren't objectively wrong. Just bad at seeing things. Blinded, always looking forward— which benefited them at times, but also served as a sort of trap— keeping them from the wide open marsh and its dried-up frogs; the sky and the servile reeds bending to touch. How beautiful was the compass on which children stood. How infinite in nature, and how unfortunate to hide from others.

Antoine appreciated adults. He really did. But he saw their faults. Instead of following base instincts, to hunt and to flee, they hunkered down and fought the air. The older one became, the more likely one was to think oneself an apex predator; which was not only incredibly dangerous, but incredibly wrong. Even Morie, not yet ripe for the disappearing, showed symptoms in the way she walked, talked, and dismissed him.

Antoine leaned against the boardwalk and let the air settle. Herons and monsters were not too unlike, he thought when the shape passed by again; long-necked and unnatural, riding flat currents like causeways.

“Look, Morie! It’s back!”

“Nice.”

La petite fille de la mer. The little girl of the sea. Sounded better in French, but Antoine digressed. It was a sad thing to deserve the sea and receive the waterless marsh. Forming a neat ‘O’ with his hands, he held fast onto the shape overhead. If he squinted hard enough, he could make out the yellow of its beak.

“He’s going to starve if there are no marsh-fish,” said Antoine disappointedly, followed by, “I think he needs the sea.”

“Great blue herons don’t need the sea, silly. White herons need the sea.”

Like how children didn’t need the sea, for if they did, they’d all become sailors and leave their babysitters behind? Antoine thought it very unfair and selfish to keep him from rescuing the heron. From rescuing himself as well. Older folk tended to leave their children behind, and here she would leave him behind. She would bite the bullet and make her first adult sacrifice.

Eventually, he and Morie reached the end of the boardwalk, which led to a forked dirt path split once towards wetter marshland, and again towards a dry hill. He made a point to avoid the hill, since he wore rain boots and his guardian had no good excuse to force him away. She'd probably let him jump off cliffs for a suitable stipend. Festooned with garlands of water, the flat yellowish grasses tickled his legs like beard hair— not that he'd know how beard hair felt, but a boy could imagine— and soon, water filled his boots. They were not nearly tall enough for marsh-walking.

Morie watched him from a safe distance, but ran on when she recalled something about crocodiles. Passing through the marsh made their bodies almost two-dimensional, flattened at the intersection of muddy streams and a wide, grey brushed sky. Made her think, for once, whether she existed in another dimension. Perhaps some liminal fourth or fifth space. Likely, she wouldn't recognize her current self. Likely, she wouldn't recognize the world. Unlikely, Antoine was a cat.

“You good with this, Morie?” He called back, voice high and mewling. To her chagrin, he continued onward.

“A monster's going to eat us,” grumbled she, followed by the expected,

“Thought you said monsters didn't exist.”

Sludge ate her white sneakers. The awkwardly secure wetness of trudging through marshland shook her as quite possibly the worst feeling on Earth. Even worse than whatever the apocalypse had in store. Deeper into wild territory, mud just barely missed the hem of her shorts and swirling shapes, maybe fish, maybe worse, tickled her calves. As if they were venturing to the end of a swimming pool, the ground seemed to slope down under them. Antoine continued. He was up to his waist in water.

“Aren’t we lucky? I thought it’d all be dry, but we might just find the sea!” Antoine leaned back, legs kept straight by layers and layers of peat, and stretched his arms out to the sky.

“We won’t find the sea if we keep going. We’ll just find more”—

She did the same, but defeatedly. An inflatable car salesman rather than a freed man.

“Dude, we’re going to miss the end of the world if we don’t...”

Adults and their adult-stuff. Morie was not wrong, because inland marshes did not ordinarily become seas, but Morie was not right either. In the distance, in every direction besides forward, spread an advancing blueness— a wide, impossible expanse— sparkling like jewels for the taking. The heron soared just a hair shy of his head; blue to white, clear to freckles on the horizon line. Moments later, what remained of the marsh had disappeared.

“Look at that!” Antoine laughed and pointed ahead. He was neck-deep now, gulping crystals of salt made solid in his mouth. His hand met Morie’s.

The spread unfolding before them *did* seem quite real. Sea-foam tickled her windpipe with every breath; the sun beat down on her face as if she stood upon a mountain; and going by past experience, it all checked out. Slightly saline, a bit of a fishy stink, and every so often, monstrous shadows in the water— but to place them she’d have to close her eyes.

To place them, she’d have to follow.

Major

Major the Firefighting Dog was a local sensation. Major wasn’t really sure why. He wasn’t the usual dalmatian stock either; rather a large, bristly mutt with strong haunches and a good nose. All his mixed blood did him well. Kept him sputtering along, even in illness.

Major liked working hard. He liked work altogether, and felt sorry that he could not work any longer. A dog out of work was a dog out of purpose. Following Firefighter Dan made him happy. Flames tickled his inner ears, and he liked how they smelled. Singed flowers. When the occasional house fire came around, he'd stand guard in front of the truck and make sure nobody stole it. Nobody ever stole it, but sometimes folks would come by and give him pets. And if the fires were serious, like the one that made him famous, they'd cling onto his wide back as he ran them to the county hospital.

The local paper wrote about him, that time. Major didn't know how to read Human, but Firefighter Dan translated it into Dog. Apparently the reporters said he was a local hero and would receive a medal soon. And everyone would come and watch, and the sirens would blare just for him. If he had a say in it he would have only opted for the sirens, but no matter.

After that, he laid low. Little children recognized him in the street. He mostly partook in educational missions—which was confusing, because he'd proven his skill, but no matter again. Four years after the fact, Firefighter Dan said he was getting a bit old for a working dog. Came into his prime late, and *look, your joints hurt, don't they buddy?* Major snuffled indignantly at any mention of 'joints'. He didn't know the word and didn't want to learn it.

The little capsules where his bones connected (at least, he assumed they were capsules) ached sometimes. Pain came and went with movement, and whenever he 'patrolled' for too long, heat shot up his hind legs. Nothing like fire-heat; it was heat from the inside that foam could not fight. A bit ashamed, he laid in the shade underneath the fire station's door. He laid there for months and months and refused to rise.

Eventually, Firefighter Dan took him home and explained that he was to be retired. 'Retired' meant taken out of work and into rest. 'Retired' meant decommissioned, tossed

aside like a shirt on a dusty back hanger, left to the moths and dry rot— and Dan was a busy man. He had fires to fight. No matter how many treats he left behind, the brand stuck hard.

Dan's house stood on a tall hill overlooking the town. Major was chained to the porch, but he had enough give to wander around when his capsules allowed for it. Sometimes he'd watch the cars go by on the main road and sometimes he'd hear voices, even though his ears were not sharp. They rang in his head like church bells. Said all sorts of silly things;

"The End of Times is nigh, brethren! Join the Church of Final Foundation lest you suffer eternal damnation and forswear enlightenment!" Major swatted a fly from his nose.

"I've got to snip my daisies, but it looks like a whole crowd of rat-shaped punks are partying in Leroy's yard. I'd better do it later." Major panted in the dry heat.

"My husband's an ass." Major gnawed on a stick and snapped it in two, surprised at his own strength. He wished the voices would leave him alone.

After some time spent weathering them, telling them in dog-speak to shut up, he realised they only became worse. As if angry at his rebuke. More thoughts, more grocery lists, more worried human cadences marching in lock-step with one another— and eventually they overlapped, dissolving into piles of unintelligible word-slop. Firefighter Dan came home less and less, but wouldn't explain why.

Then Firefighter Dan left for good. Major waited and waited and waited despite the voices. He waited some more. Day turned to night and stars sparkled in his eyes, but Firefighter Dan did not return. Major decided to break his own chain, because he'd been able to all along.

“Ravi *sucks*. Why can’t he just follow me and shut up?” Thought.

“Tomorrow, we begin our conquest! To the news building!” Thought.

“A monster? No, no— it’s a heron. Look at the neck, dude. Monsters don’t exist.”

Dialogue?

Major didn’t feel bad or anything. About Dan leaving him. Not at all. Humans had important business to cover all the time, and that was why they abandoned their pets sometimes— but really, it was no fault of either party. Humans meant well, and Dan had taken very good care of him while the hours lasted.

“...Well, *that’s* what I’m doing.” Dialogue.

Dan had loads of interesting equipment lying around his backyard. On May 23rd, still dark, Major grew especially hungry and bored. His food bowl was near-empty. That morning he slipped through a space in the fence posts, since he’d gotten thin enough, and went about exploring.

If exploring was his new job, he would do it well. Exploring. Looking for food. Looking for a way to stop the voices, maybe. Hunger hurt him, but not so much as the constant drone of mortal burden— something that his dog-brain did not comprehend.

He poked through some things on stumps, maybe saws, and nearly cut his paw on a sharp glint of silver in the grass. Dan liked carving animals into wood. He was not so good at organising his tools.

“He calls himself Jessup these days, does he?” Dialogue *and* thought.

One tool interested him in particular. It looked like he might be able to find food with it, since it was large and powerful like him. Or how he used to be. He spent about thirty

minutes dragging the thing from Dan's open shed, hanging on with his teeth. Then he dropped it over top of the silver glint, and the silver glint was no more. That was an accident.

Major fumbled around with his nose in search of an 'ON' button. Firetruck lights had 'ON' buttons, which he knew very well. Unfortunately, there was no such button on this tool.

He resorted to biting it wherever he could. First he bit the sharp end— were those chains?— and hurt his lip. The metal sent cold sparks coursing through his jawbone.

“He's going to starve if there are no marsh-fish.” Dialogue.

He wanted to be useful. He really did. He wanted to fend for himself and use tools like Dan, and if or when the firefighter returned, he'd show him that he was still ready to work because, see, he could hunt animals with the sharp bits.

“Poor sod doesn't know what they're doing. Guess I'll set them straight.” Thought.

It looked a bit like how he'd imagine a metal crocodile to look. Although it had no jaws for biting and no beady little eyes. He eventually found a sort of switch, which he nudged with his nose, but nothing happened.

The bits and baubles on this contraption were near-impossible to figure out, and he cut his losses by adjusting each one however he saw fit. In doing so, he noticed the next most promising component; a curve, presumably for human grip.

He tugged on the curve with his paw.

Again, nothing happened.

“Today a wolf-shape sleeps in shadow.” Oddity.

Finnicking around, wiggling the curve into all sorts of positions, he eventually found a string— thin and inviting like a rat’s tail. All the better to bite. Firmly clamped between his jaws, he yanked the string. Dogs loved yanking things.

He yanked it once, twice, thrice— without much give, paws still holding the body in place— and finally, something sleeping inside revved to life. A hidden grumble. A beast’s belly, sonorous and deep as the stormwinds but quick as the streams that had long since left the town. The tool’s chains were vibrating. Buzz. Buzz. Loudly.

Before Major could wonder *how* exactly to lift the thing up, what with bad bones, he lost his stable grip on the handle. Tipping downward into the grass, then sideways into the silver glint he’d forgotten about, sparks began to fly. Bright sparks, flecks of white that sent Major skittering back. Some caught him on the nose, burning holes through his skin. He wouldn’t dare come closer to shut the thing off.

“Thought you said monsters didn’t exist.” Why now? Still, why now?

From a safe distance, he watched these sparks catch the brown and yellow grass, eating it for all its brittleness, crunch-crunching on hard stalks. He’d ruined Dan’s lawn. He’d let it burst aflame without recourse or damage control. Even he, the firefighting dog, was useless without equipment.

Vibrations forced Major’s tears from their ducts, but he wasn’t sad so much as confused. Dogs preferred crying aloud. His only comfort was the familiar smell of chaos; burning matter; smoke and pungent air like paint strokes over warm sponge-brushing, diffused at the edges. The voices rose, much louder than usual, and began to yell at him with rude recourse. “We’re running out of rations!”; “When’s enlightenment coming? I’m tired of this!”; “You idiot!”. Major barked in response.

He wouldn't admit it, but he loved fire more than fighting fire. And a dog out of love was a dog out of purpose. Free of his chains, he sat and watched the flames consume the firefighter's yard. His fur began to singe and crackle. As it did he ran, wind blowing his way, and skidded to a halt at the hill's edge. Front yard met dusty slope.

If the fire continued after him, hungry for more, then it would hurt all the sweet humans below. And some might die. His body was not fuel enough for an undying appetite, as much as he appreciated helping. He also loved helping *people*— and considered running down, aches and all, to warn them of the disaster to come. But perhaps he shouldn't; and perhaps they needed something new.

Fire, even in his simple dog-brain, very obviously meant renewal. Here he was; old, decrepit, little to his name besides a rescue and a symbol. There the town was; old, decrepit, nothing to its name besides whatever had happened in preparation for the end. If they could all be cleansed at once, not out of evil but need, then that would be alright. No need for hunting or proving himself or wishing for Dan's return, which he'd kept in spirit but abandoned otherwise.

Like Jessup, like the doctor's daughter, like the sea, like those who acted before knowing why, Major reflected on the dumb luck that a silver piece— maybe a coin, a carving knife— came into contact with his buzzing-tool and sent sparks to the grass. If he hadn't traced the exact steps to enact such an event, he would have starved to death without watching the works one last time. And that would have been tragic.

Finally, the voices were dead quiet. Quiet as the dead.

Major tossed his head as if to push their wet remainders from his ears. Fur whipping in the wind, he howled a dog-song. He was glad to become a regular creature again, absent of telepathic links and things he did not understand. Absent of heroism.

Though the fire set his skin on needles at every point, he clung to himself with no need for transport. He felt the strong, solid pelt on his back— and was happy.

Hard work made him happy.

Fire 2

The great fire came on the twenty-third of March. There were no survivors to speak of; none to recount their experiences and daring rescues. Dog boys barked their loudest. Dogwood rustled. Rats danced the cancan in outer space. Minors, majors, poets, and cult leaders resigned themselves to suffering. And they all died, one way or another. And they were stories. And the world burnt, because stories are told best with sufficient tragedy. And stories always, *always* end.

Burning alive is painful. You may die from shock or carbon monoxide poisoning first, which is a nicer way to go— imagine Jessup forcing his lids closed, forcing himself into pleasant sleep— or you may kill yourself. Severe burns are quite difficult to treat, since the immune system works its magic and sends blood to affected areas. When the case is widespread, dehydration sets in and suddenly the body becomes a water-filled pincushion. Burning alive is painful. No one lived to tell the tale (besides science, including the doctor who believed she was science).

Poetically, the burning town was beautiful. Hell on Earth in nature's rope, ecliptic beads of fire tracing the hilltops, the orange-black of a ceiling fully taken by flame; romantic, sublime, uncontrollable even *with* proper equipment, which citizens lacked anyway— and all

the pain, natural retribution wrought upon their souls, seemed alright. The sort of seeming you'd get from cows turning to beef jerky. Humans turning to human jerky. It is no large feat; imagining hordes of bodies clamouring over one another, seeking an out as one form melts into another, the pain of millions of nerves set off at once— then, when the severity wanes, nothing at all. Adrenaline, regular heartbeats, then not-so-regular heartbeats. Sylvia Milne, wherever she ended up, was likely quite happy she'd died.

Poetically again, all the townsfolk were connected by the same red string of fate. Albeit a shrivelled string, a dumb string. They saw the world as an object encompassed by their purview, and anything beyond did not exist. The world saw them as an object too, invisible as it was useless. Life passed by in regular, locomotory fashion elsewhere; a Chinese schoolboy sat for lunch; an Icelandic farmer poured themselves a glass of water; a Peruvian weaver rolled out long bands of peacock-coloured thread, and none thought one bit about the small, strange place burning to death.

Would anybody remember its existence? The erasure of a vaguely town-shaped spot on the map that may or may not have 'been' in the first place? No, better question; if an ant screams in a forest, does it scream at all?

Beings can be obtuse, as obvious. These ones' propensities for ignorance and overblown reactions could have earned them a world record. But tenderness cut the loss, as *equally* obvious in baby rats and seafarers and the small brush-past touches that left affection unsung. It is difficult to hate them, even after pointing out bits like; they could have simply thought for themselves. They could have merely adjusted their circumstances here or there.

They become endearing by the way they scuttle. Destruction becomes deliverance, like taking mercy on a dying spider.

One may also argue that nobody can help themselves. Stories— bodies— beings— the vessels in which rat guts swirl— are wired to love what does not love them back.

(More can be told, I'd say, of a dog on a hill and boys becoming dogs, and seas and seas as far as the eye will go. And much more too, for the imagination works wonders. But this is all we'll get for now, and the gory details deserve sparing. Truth can speak for itself. Thoughts are not half as trustworthy).